

To: Indie Studio Leadership  
Date: June 12, 2026  
Re: Steam Launch Strategy Recommendation

The major genres to avoid are Racing and Sports as they have a high initial cost. Additionally, Massively Multiplayer is dominated by big titles, thus it might prove harder to gain a player base with such competitions. On the contrary, genres such as Action, RPG, and Adventure should warrant consideration as they are one of the most popular where players demonstrate strong engagement with new titles. The Free price tier should be avoided because it is dominated by big titles and the Budget tier (\$0.01 - \$9.99) contains vastly more games than any other genres and it could prove hard to get a consistent player base. Lastly, the game should be released in the Q3 - Q4 as they consistently garner the highest average recommendations.

Approximately, 170,000 applications were sourced directly from Steam's API system and after filtering non-games, unreleased games, software applications, etc. roughly 20,500 games were retained. The games ranged from 1998 to June, 2026, about a 28 year window.

The findings show that genre has minimal correlation with metacritic scores, so any genre can be explored in that aspect. However, higher priced games showed higher metacritic scores on average and also attracted more community engagement (recommendations). The Sports and Racing genre had the most expensive games on average but had significantly less community engagement comparatively. Massively Multiplayer ranks as the highest recommended genre on average, though it is dominated by big titles. As a result, Action ranks the second highest, double compared to RPG and Adventure. Lastly, August averaged 23,000 recommendations, approximately double November and December.

Based on this analysis, we recommend launching as an Action, RPG, or Adventure game that is priced in the Standard to Premium tier (\$20 - \$39.99) with the release date in August or November. Firstly, the aforementioned genres were the top three average recommended genres, behind Massively Multiplayer. The Standard tier averages 9,156 recommendations and Premium averages 24,628, significantly higher than Budget at ~4,000. Finally, August was the most popular month with the highest recommendations followed by November, so a release date in those months could allow for the highest chance of discovery.

Several limitations should be noted for this analysis. The data does not contain live player count over the years and how DLCs or game updates impact player retention. Those pieces of data could provide further information as to how a game could be kept robust for years. Furthermore, no metrics can show the reputation of the studio, which does play a critical role in how people choose which games to purchase next.